

The Precarious Professor: Adjunct Labor, Job Insecurity, and Mental Health in Higher Education

The Issue

The shift toward adjunct and contingent faculty in colleges has fundamentally transformed higher education into a two-tiered caste system: a shrinking, privileged class of tenured or tenure-track professors with job security, benefits, offices, research support, and institutional voice, and a growing majority—now over 70% of all college instructors in the United States—of highly educated instructors living in financial precarity, cycling between short-term contracts with no guarantee of future employment, no pathway to stability, and no recognition as full members of the academic community (Johnson and Fuesting; American Association of University Professors; Government Accountability Office; Kezar et al.). This workforce teaches the majority of undergraduate courses—the foundational education that students and families pay tens of thousands of dollars to receive—while earning poverty wages, receiving no benefits, having virtually no institutional support, and being systematically excluded from governance and decision-making ("Adjunct Faculty in the Higher Education Workforce"; Coalition on the Academic Workforce; House Committee on Education and the Workforce). The consequences are severe and far-reaching: adjunct faculty experience depression, anxiety disorders, and burnout at alarming rates, yet mental health resources and workplace accommodations are rarely available (Tucker et al.; Evans et al.; Levecque et al.). This exploitation undermines not only the lives, dignity, and mental health of instructors, but also the quality of education students receive (Ehrenberg and Zhang; Umbach), the integrity of higher education as an institution (Readings; Ginsberg), and the promise of education as a pathway to economic security and meaningful work (Childress; Kezar et al.).

Why It Matters

The Economics of Exploitation

- Adjuncts earn poverty wages (often \$2,000-\$5,000 per course) with no benefits, job security, or institutional support. A typical adjunct teaching load of 3-4 courses per semester (considered "part-time" despite being functionally full-time work requiring 30-50 hours per week) yields annual earnings of \$12,000-\$30,000—well below livable wages in most areas and below the federal poverty line for a family. Many adjuncts earn less than \$25,000 annually despite holding master's degrees or PhDs and working full-time hours (Johnson and Fuesting; American

Federation of Teachers; Government Accountability Office; Coalition on the Academic Workforce).

- Per-course pay varies wildly by institution type, geographic location, and discipline, ranging from as low as \$1,500-\$2,000 per course at community colleges to \$3,000-\$7,000 at elite private institutions—but even the "high" end is exploitative when the actual hours of work are calculated (Johnson; House Committee on Education and the Workforce; American Association of University Professors).
- When all work hours are counted—course preparation, teaching contact hours, grading, office hours, email correspondence, learning new technology, attending required meetings—adjuncts often earn \$10-\$15 per hour or less, well below minimum wage in many jurisdictions and unconscionable for workers with terminal degrees and specialized expertise (Magness; "Adjuncts Emphasize Need for Contracts"; American Federation of Teachers; Childress).
- Pay has stagnated or declined over decades while tuition and administrative salaries have soared. Adjusted for inflation, adjuncts today earn roughly the same or less per course than adjuncts did 30-40 years ago, despite significantly higher credential requirements (many positions now require PhDs where master's degrees once sufficed), increased workload expectations (technology integration, learning management systems, assessment documentation), and dramatically increased cost of living, student debt burdens, and healthcare costs ("2025 Higher Education Price Index"; American Association of University Professors; Kezar and Maxey).
- Meanwhile, tuition has increased 169% at public four-year institutions and 200%+ at private institutions since 1980, while administrative salaries have ballooned (university presidents now commonly earn \$500,000-\$1,000,000+, provosts and deans earn \$200,000-\$500,000), and spending on facilities, athletics, and branding has exploded. The money exists—it's simply not going to teaching ("Recent Trends in the Cost of College"; Ginsberg; Newfield; Slaughter and Rhoades).
- No health insurance, retirement benefits, or paid leave. Adjuncts classified as "part-time" (even when teaching full-time course loads) are excluded from employer-provided benefits. They must find their own insurance (often unaffordable at \$400-\$800+ per month for individual coverage, more for families), have no employer retirement contributions (meaning they're building no security for old age despite working their entire careers), and receive absolutely no pay when sick, caring for ill family members, bereaved, or between semesters ("Adjunct Faculty | Current Employees"; Government Accountability Office; American Federation of Teachers; Childress).
- Summer and winter breaks mean no income, not vacation. The 3-4 month summer gap and winter break create financial crises. Adjuncts must either find other work (undermining the fiction that this is "part-time" supplemental employment), drain savings they don't have, go into debt, or apply for unemployment benefits (which some states deny to academic workers, and

which carry stigma and bureaucratic burden) (House Committee on Education and the Workforce; Kenner and Bacon).

- Healthcare insecurity is life-threatening. Adjuncts delay or forgo necessary medical care, dental care, mental health treatment, and prescription medications due to cost. Preventable conditions become serious; chronic conditions worsen. Some have died from treatable illnesses because they couldn't afford care (Childress; Kenner and Bacon; "An Army of Temps").
- No compensation for non-teaching work. Office hours, student advising, email correspondence (which has exploded with digital communication), learning management system maintenance, committee service, professional development, curriculum development, assessment and accreditation work, attending department meetings, writing recommendation letters, and countless other administrative tasks are either completely unpaid or nominally "included" in the per-course rate—meaning adjuncts effectively work for far below minimum wage when all hours are counted. The per-course payment assumes perhaps 10-15 hours of work per week; the reality is often 20-30+ hours per course (Coalition on the Academic Workforce; American Federation of Teachers; Magness).
- The expectation of invisible labor is gendered and racialized. Women adjuncts and adjuncts of color disproportionately provide emotional labor, mentoring, diversity work, and student support—unpaid, unrecognized, and expected (Misra et al.; Guarino and Borden; Griffin et al.).
- No job security or contracts beyond a single semester. Adjuncts typically receive contracts just weeks before the semester begins—sometimes even after classes start—meaning they cannot plan financially or professionally more than a few weeks ahead. They have no guarantee of future employment, no right to renewal, and can be let go at any time without cause, due process, or appeal. Courses can be cancelled at the last minute due to low enrollment, eliminating expected income with no notice or compensation ("Adjuncts Emphasize Need for Contracts"; Kezar et al.; Childress; House Committee on Education and the Workforce).
- The precarity is deliberate. Short-term contracts keep adjuncts powerless, desperate, and compliant. They cannot risk advocating for themselves, questioning decisions, or organizing collectively when their jobs disappear with a single email (Bousquet; Kezar et al.).
- No unemployment benefits in some states because adjuncts are classified as having "reasonable assurance" of future employment (even when they don't), denying them even this minimal safety net (House Committee on Education and the Workforce).
- The "permatemp" trap: Some adjuncts teach at the same institution for years or decades, doing the same work as tenure-track faculty, yet remain in precarious positions with no pathway to stability. They are essential to institutional functioning—carrying full course loads year after year, maintaining curricular continuity, serving students, developing expertise in teaching specific courses—but treated as disposable temporary workers. They train new adjuncts who are hired into the same exploitative conditions. They watch tenure-track positions in their

departments remain unfilled or be eliminated entirely while their own jobs remain precarious (Childress; Kezar et al.; Bousquet).

- Long-term adjuncts experience particular anguish: the realization that this isn't temporary, that the tenure-track job isn't coming, that this is their career, that they've been exploited for years and will continue to be until they can no longer sustain it (Childress; Cassuto).
- Many work at multiple institutions simultaneously, leading to exhaustion and inability to fully support students. "Freeway flyers" or "road scholars" cobble together courses at 2-4 different colleges (sometimes more), spending 10-20 hours per week commuting between campuses in different cities, juggling different learning management systems, department cultures, policies, academic calendars, and student populations. This is survival, not choice. The logistics are nightmarish—office hours at Campus A, teaching at Campus B, racing to Campus C, grading in the car, eating fast food on the highway, answering emails on smartphones at stoplights (American Federation of Teachers; Coalition on the Academic Workforce; Childress).
- The commuting adjunct lifestyle is financially devastating: Gas, car maintenance, parking fees, professional clothing, and food consume significant portions of poverty wages. The time spent commuting is unpaid. The stress is immense (Childress; Kenner and Bacon).
- Freeway flying makes excellent teaching impossible. Adjuncts cannot build relationships with students when they're racing out the door. They cannot maintain consistent office hours. They cannot participate in campus life or professional community. They cannot invest in course design when teaching six different courses across three institutions with three different LMS platforms (Umbach; Ehrenberg and Zhang).

The Human Cost: Mental Health in Freefall

- Financial stress, instability, and lack of respect contribute to anxiety, depression, and burnout. The constant, unrelenting uncertainty of whether you'll have income next semester, whether you can afford rent next month, whether you should go to the doctor for concerning symptoms, whether you can afford groceries or must choose between food and medication—this chronic financial stress is psychologically devastating, creating a state of perpetual crisis and hypervigilance (Tucker et al.; Evans et al.; Levecque et al.; Mullainathan and Shafir).
- Mental health struggles among adjuncts are high due to financial stress and lack of institutional support. Studies show adjunct faculty experience clinical depression, generalized anxiety disorder, panic disorder, and suicidal ideation at rates far exceeding the general population and even other precarious workers. Some research suggests rates of depression among adjuncts may reach 40-50%, nearly triple the general population (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.; Flaherty, "Mental Health Crisis").
- The cognitive load of financial precarity impairs functioning. Groundbreaking research by Sendhil Mullainathan and Eldar Shafir demonstrates that poverty and financial insecurity consume cognitive bandwidth—the mental energy and executive function capacity needed to

plan, problem-solve, regulate emotions, and make good decisions. Financial scarcity creates a cognitive tax that impairs performance on unrelated tasks. Adjuncts are trying to teach complex material, design engaging lessons, provide thoughtful feedback, and support students' intellectual growth while their brains are screaming about unpaid bills, overdraft fees, collection calls, and survival fears. They're operating with diminished cognitive capacity through no fault of their own (Mullainathan and Shafir).

- Decision fatigue is constant: Which bill to pay? Which credit card to use? Whether to buy groceries or put gas in the car to get to campus? These decisions drain mental resources needed for teaching and scholarship (Mullainathan and Shafir).
- Food and housing insecurity are common, not exceptional. Some adjuncts qualify for food stamps (SNAP benefits), Medicaid, or housing assistance despite having PhDs and teaching college—the ultimate indictment of the system. Stories of adjuncts living in cars (sleeping in campus parking lots or Walmart parking lots), sleeping in campus offices (hiding from security, using gym showers), couch-surfing with friends or former students, living in cheap motels, or relying on food banks are not rare outliers sensationalized by media—they're systemic outcomes of poverty wages. Multiple adjuncts have publicly shared these experiences; many more suffer silently in shame ("Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Kenner and Bacon; Goldrick-Rab et al.; Childress).
- Mary-Faith Cerasoli, an adjunct who lived in her car while teaching, wrote about her experience, helping break the silence around adjunct poverty. Margaret Mary Vojtko, an 83-year-old adjunct at Duquesne University, died in poverty in 2013 after being denied health insurance and fired from her \$3,000 per course position. Her story briefly captured national attention, but the system that killed her remains unchanged (Childress; Bousquet).
- Housing costs consume 50-70% or more of adjunct income in expensive urban areas where many universities are located, forcing impossible choices between safe housing and other necessities ("Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Kenner and Bacon; Government Accountability Office).
- Food insecurity means going hungry, skipping meals, living on cheap processed foods that undermine health. Some adjuncts rely on campus food banks meant for students. Some eat only once per day. Some depend on student organizations' free pizza events or foraging free food from campus events (Kenner and Bacon; Goldrick-Rab et al.).
- Healthcare is often completely inaccessible. Without employer-provided insurance and unable to afford \$400-\$800+ monthly premiums plus high deductibles, adjuncts may go years or decades without seeing a doctor or dentist ("An Army of Temps"; American Federation of Teachers; Government Accountability Office; Childress), delay or avoid treatment for concerning symptoms and chronic conditions, ration or skip prescription medications, leave treatable conditions untreated until they become serious or life-threatening, and face medical debt and bankruptcy when emergencies force treatment.

- Mental health care is particularly unaffordable, requiring out-of-pocket payment of \$100-\$250+ per session and long-term commitment (depression and anxiety require months or years of treatment) that adjuncts cannot sustain financially. Insurance, when they have it, often has high copays (\$40-\$60) and limited mental health coverage ("Zencare Study"; Evans et al.; Levecque et al.; American Federation of Teachers). The cruelty is profound: the workers who need mental health care most urgently have the least access to it.
- Dental care is a luxury. Adjuncts with painful cavities, broken teeth, or gum disease may go untreated for years because they cannot afford hundreds or thousands of dollars for dental work. Some have lost teeth that could have been saved with early treatment (Childress; Kenner and Bacon).
- Prescription medications are rationed or skipped. Adjuncts with diabetes, hypertension, thyroid conditions, depression, or other conditions requiring medication may skip doses, split pills, or go without—risking serious health consequences—because they cannot afford \$50-\$200+ monthly medication costs (American Federation of Teachers; Kenner and Bacon).
- Preventive care is impossible. No annual check-ups, no screening tests, no vaccinations. Problems aren't caught early; by the time adjuncts seek care, conditions may be advanced and more expensive to treat—creating worse outcomes and greater financial burden (Childress; "An Army of Temps").
- The shame and isolation are profound and corrosive. Adjuncts often hide their circumstances from colleagues, students, family, and friends. There's deep, internalized shame in being highly educated—often the first in their families to attend college, holding prestigious PhDs from respected universities—yet struggling financially, unable to afford basics, living worse than undergraduates they teach. There's shame in having "failed" to secure a tenure-track position in an impossible, rigged job market where dozens or hundreds of brilliant PhDs compete for single positions. There's shame in not being able to provide stability for oneself, one's partner, or one's family despite doing everything "right": working hard, getting education, pursuing meaningful work (Childress; Cassuto; Bousquet).
- Adjuncts hide poverty from students who assume their professor is securely middle-class. They dress professionally despite not being able to afford it, maintain appearances, perform the role of "professor" while living in cars or skipping meals. The performance is exhausting (Childress).
- Adjuncts hide struggles from tenure-track colleagues who may not understand the vast gulf in experience between their positions, who may judge or pity, or whose well-meaning sympathy feels humiliating. Department meetings where tenure-track faculty discuss sabbatical plans, conference travel, and book manuscripts while adjuncts worry about rent create painful cognitive dissonance (Kezar et al.; Childress).
- Family relationships suffer. Partners may not understand why someone with a PhD can't find a "real job." Adult children may be embarrassed by their parent's poverty. Parents who sacrificed

for their child's education may not understand why it hasn't led to security. The disconnect between education and outcomes violates the social narrative everyone was taught to believe (Childress; Cassuto).

- Social isolation intensifies. Adjuncts cannot afford to socialize—no money for meals out, drinks, entertainment, professional conferences, or even gas money to visit friends. They disappear from social circles, reinforcing isolation that exacerbates mental health struggles (Evans et al.; American Federation of Teachers).
- Mental health struggles are hidden due to fear of losing already-tenuous positions. Adjuncts cannot afford to disclose mental health challenges, request accommodations, or even acknowledge struggles to supervisors or colleagues. In a profession that values intellectual capacity and emotional stability, admitting anxiety, depression, or distress feels like confirming one's inadequacy—that you're "not cut out" for academia, not resilient enough, not worthy of better. Admitting struggles could lead to not being rehired, contracts not renewed, whispered concerns about your "fitness" to teach—the worst fear realized (Levecque et al.; Evans et al.; Childress).
- The system depends on silence. Adjuncts stay quiet, suffer privately, and the exploitation continues unexamined. Those who speak out risk professional retaliation and blacklisting (Berry; Bousquet).
- Compassion fatigue from supporting students' trauma and needs takes a toll on teachers' own well-being. Adjuncts still provide substantial emotional labor—responding to student mental health crises (which have skyrocketed), writing extensive recommendation letters (unpaid work requiring hours per letter), mentoring students through academic and personal challenges, counseling students in distress, accommodating students' needs, and maintaining warm, supportive classroom environments—all while battling their own mental health struggles, financial desperation, and complete lack of institutional support. The contrast between supporting others while drowning oneself creates profound moral injury and cognitive dissonance (Misra et al.; Guarino and Borden; American Federation of Teachers).
- Adjuncts may identify more with struggling students (first-generation, working-class, students of color, those facing financial hardship) because they share those experiences—but this increases vicarious trauma and emotional burden without resources to process it (American Federation of Teachers; Childress).
- Suicidal ideation and attempts occur but are rarely discussed openly. The combination of financial desperation, professional disappointment and loss of identity, social isolation and loneliness, shame and worthlessness, hopelessness about the future, and feeling trapped with no escape creates conditions where some adjuncts think about or attempt suicide. Some have died by suicide, their stories briefly acknowledged with shock and sympathy before being forgotten while the system that killed them continues unchanged (Evans et al.; Flaherty, "Mental Health Crisis"; Levecque et al.).

- The academic job market crisis has been linked to several suicides among graduate students and adjuncts. Each is treated as individual tragedy rather than systemic outcome. The loss is immeasurable—brilliant minds, dedicated teachers, valuable human beings destroyed by an exploitative system (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.).
- Grief and loss are constant. Adjuncts grieve the careers they trained for but will never have, the lives they imagined but cannot build, the passion for teaching that's being crushed by precarity, the community and belonging they're excluded from, and their own sense of self and purpose (Childress; Cassuto).

The Institutional Abandonment

- Teaching is one of the most demanding intellectual and emotional professions, yet adjuncts are expected to "push through" without support. Adjuncts are expected to maintain the same teaching quality, pedagogical innovation, student responsiveness, availability, and professional standards as tenure-track faculty who earn 3-5 times as much, have benefits and security, offices and research support, manageable course loads, and institutional standing—but adjuncts must do it with poverty wages, no benefits, no security, no office, no resources, and no recognition. The expectation is not just unreasonable—it's delusional and cruel (Umbach; Childress; Kezar et al.).
- Excellence under these conditions is miraculous, not expected. When adjuncts do excellent work—and many do, out of commitment to students and craft—it should be recognized as heroic, not treated as baseline expectation (Childress).
- Schools often completely lack Employee Assistance Programs (EAPs) or mental health days for adjuncts. Benefits available to full-time faculty and staff—free confidential counseling through EAPs, mental health days or wellness leave, stress management programs, health and wellness initiatives, gym access, childcare assistance—are typically denied entirely to adjunct faculty classified as "part-time" regardless of actual workload. Many adjuncts don't even know these benefits exist for their tenure-track colleagues; the two-tier system is designed to be opaque (American Federation of Teachers; "Adjunct Faculty | Current Employees"; Kezar et al.).
- The message is clear: Your well-being doesn't matter. You're not really part of this community (Childress; Bousquet).
- No paid sick days means teaching while ill or losing income entirely. Adjuncts show up to class with the flu, bronchitis, stomach viruses—risking their health and exposing students—because missing class means not getting paid (losing \$200-\$500 for a single absence, which could be the difference between paying rent or not) and potentially risking contract renewal (being seen as "unreliable"). They teach after family emergencies, during mental health crises, while dealing with domestic violence, after deaths of loved ones—because there is no paid leave, no coverage, no alternative (American Federation of Teachers; Government Accountability Office).

- Finding substitutes is often the adjunct's responsibility, adding another layer of burden when ill or in crisis. Some adjuncts have had to cancel classes (and lose pay) because they couldn't find coverage while hospitalized (Childress).
- Stigma prevents teachers from disclosing struggles for fear of being seen as "weak," "unprofessional," or unfit for teaching. In academia—which valorizes intellectual brilliance, productivity, and rigor while viewing mental health struggles as personal weakness—admitting depression, anxiety, burnout, or distress feels like professional suicide. Mental health challenges are seen as individual failures rather than systemic outcomes. Adjuncts fear that admitting difficulties will confirm what they dread others think: that they're not "good enough" for tenure-track positions, not resilient enough for academia, not worthy of better treatment. The stigma is particularly intense because the achievement of a PhD supposedly signifies intellectual excellence and capability—struggling despite this credential feels like fundamental personal failure (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.; Childress).
- Academic culture often equates struggle with inadequacy. If you can't handle it, you don't belong—never mind that the conditions are inhumane and designed to extract maximum labor for minimum compensation (Bousquet; Kezar et al.).
- No office space, resources, or institutional belonging. Many adjuncts lack dedicated office space, instead meeting students in hallways, noisy cafeterias, campus coffee shops, or their cars (when they have cars). Some share one office among 10-20 adjuncts—no privacy for student conversations, no space to work, no professional environment for consultations about sensitive topics (grades, mental health, trauma). They may not have campus email addresses (forced to use personal email, creating confusion for students and lack of institutional identity), library borrowing privileges, access to academic databases needed for research and course prep, parking permits (having to pay to park to teach), ID badges (creating access barriers and security hassles), or inclusion in department communications (finding out about policy changes, cancelled classes, or important information late or not at all). This physical and social exclusion compounds feelings of worthlessness, invisibility, and not belonging—treating adjuncts as literally not part of the campus community despite doing essential institutional work (Coalition on the Academic Workforce; American Federation of Teachers; Childress).
- The symbolic violence of exclusion is profound. Not having a faculty ID, a campus email, or an office communicates: You're not really faculty. You don't belong here. You're not one of us (Childress; Kezar et al.).
- Adjuncts may be excluded from faculty meetings, social events, email lists, and informal networks where important information and opportunities circulate. They're structurally isolated (Coalition on the Academic Workforce; Rhoades).
- Adjuncts are excluded from governance and decision-making despite doing the majority of teaching. They typically have no vote in curriculum decisions, no input on hiring or personnel decisions, no representation in faculty senate or departmental governance, and no voice in

institutional policies that directly affect their work (course caps, prerequisites, learning management systems, assessment requirements, academic calendars). They are labor inputs, not colleagues. Decisions about their working conditions are made without their participation or consent (Rhoades; Kezar et al.; American Association of University Professors; "Annual Report on the Economic Status of the Profession, 2024-25").

- This disempowerment violates basic principles of workplace democracy and shared governance that higher education supposedly values. Adjuncts have less workplace power than fast-food workers in some states (Bousquet; Berry).
- Professional development is often unavailable or uncompensated. Tenure-track faculty receive funding for conferences, workshops, research, and professional growth. Adjuncts must pay out-of-pocket (impossible on poverty wages) or forgo professional development entirely, stagnating their skills and careers (American Federation of Teachers; Coalition on the Academic Workforce).

The Structural Shift: How We Got Here

- Full-time tenure-track positions are disappearing, shifting higher education toward a gig-economy model. In the 1970s, tenure-track faculty taught approximately 70% of undergraduate courses. Today, contingent faculty (adjuncts, lecturers, graduate students) teach 70%+ of undergraduate courses, and in some institutions the figure exceeds 80% (June; Schuster and Finkelstein; American Association of University Professors; Kezar et al.). The tenure-track job has become a rare, privileged position rather than the norm. This isn't accidental, organic, or a response to temporary budget crises—it's a deliberate, systematic restructuring of academic labor designed to cut costs, increase management flexibility and control, and shift risk onto workers (Bousquet; Slaughter and Rhoades).
- The adjunctification of higher education accelerated in the 1980s-1990s with neoliberal restructuring of universities, state disinvestment in public higher education, and the embrace of corporate management models (Slaughter and Rhoades; Newfield; Giroux).
- Tenured faculty are retiring or dying; their lines are not being refilled with tenure-track hires but instead replaced with multiple adjunct positions or not replaced at all. Departments that once had 15 tenure-track faculty now have 5-6, with the teaching done by 20-30 adjuncts (Schuster and Finkelstein; Kezar and Maxey).
- Universities operate like corporations, prioritizing profit margins and operational efficiency over educational mission, student learning, or worker dignity. Administrators—many from business backgrounds rather than academic backgrounds—apply business logic: Labor is the biggest expense, so cut labor costs by replacing expensive tenure-track faculty (earning \$60,000-\$100,000+ with benefits, costing institutions \$80,000-\$150,000 total) with cheap adjuncts (earning \$2,000-\$5,000 per course with zero benefits, costing institutions exactly what

they're paid). The cost savings are enormous—potentially 70-80% reduction in instructional costs (Titus et al.; Ginsberg; Slaughter and Rhoades; Bousquet).

- But the savings don't go to students through lower tuition or to teaching quality through smaller classes or better resources—they fund administrative bloat (the number of administrators has grown vastly faster than faculty), expanded facilities (luxury dorms, climbing walls, lazy rivers, state-of-the-art athletic facilities), athletics programs, branding and marketing, and endowment growth. Universities have more money than ever—they're just choosing not to spend it on teaching ("AFT Report: Pandemic Intensified Job Insecurity"; Ginsberg; Newfield).
- Administrative salaries have exploded while instructional salaries have stagnated or declined. The ratio of administrator pay to faculty pay has grown dramatically. The ratio of administrators to students has also grown while faculty-to-student ratios have worsened ("Annual Report on the Economic Status of the Profession, 2024-25"; Ginsberg).
- Higher education has been financialized: Universities function like investment firms managing endowments (some exceeding \$10-\$50 billion) while treating education as a product and students as customers/revenue sources ("How Harvard University's Funding Works"; Slaughter and Rhoades; Brown; Readings).
- The PhD overproduction pipeline deliberately feeds the adjunct system. Universities continue admitting large cohorts of graduate students—often 8-15 per year per program—training them specifically for tenure-track research jobs, despite knowing that tenure-track jobs don't exist (perhaps 1-2 jobs open annually in entire disciplines) (Roy et al.; Cassuto; Larson et al.; Bousquet). Then these same universities hire their overproduced PhDs as adjuncts, exploiting their labor at poverty wages while they desperately hope for a "real" job that will never materialize. The system is designed to produce a surplus labor pool that keeps wages low and workers compliant.
- Graduate programs are complicit: They benefit from graduate student labor (teaching, research, grading) at exploitative rates (stipends of \$15,000-\$30,000 for full-time work) while claiming to "train scholars." They maintain prestige through PhD production without accountability for job outcomes (Cassuto; Larson et al.).
- The "job market" narrative misleads graduate students into believing jobs exist but they're just competitive, rather than revealing the truth: there are no jobs, the system produced 10-20 times more PhDs than positions, and most will never have the careers they trained for (Cassuto; Larson et al.; Childress).
- "Adjunct" has become a misnomer—a euphemism that obscures exploitation. The term originally meant supplementary instructors—professionals bringing real-world expertise into the classroom part-time to enrich academic study (the lawyer teaching business law one evening, the journalist teaching writing). Now it's a euphemism for a permanent underclass doing core institutional work (teaching required general education courses, major courses, and entire programs) for poverty wages. True "adjunct" work—supplemental, part-time, enrichment

—describes perhaps 10-20% of current adjunct positions. The rest is structural exploitation masked by misleading terminology (Johnson and Fuesting; Bousquet; Kezar et al.; Childress).

- Renaming matters: "Contingent faculty" or "precarious academic workers" more accurately describes the reality, but institutions resist this language because it reveals the exploitation (Bousquet).
- The promise of "flexibility" is a lie and a manipulation. Adjuncting is marketed as flexible work for those who want part-time employment—retirees staying engaged, professionals sharing expertise, parents with caregiving responsibilities choosing reduced hours. In reality, the vast majority of adjuncts want full-time, stable positions with benefits but are trapped in precarity against their will. The "choice" framing blames workers for their circumstances and obscures that institutions have deliberately chosen this labor model to profit from desperation. Schedules change semester to semester with no worker input, courses are assigned or cancelled arbitrarily, and adjuncts have no control over when or what they teach—hardly "flexibility" (Coalition on the Academic Workforce; American Federation of Teachers; Kezar et al.).
- The flexibility benefits institutions, not workers: They can expand or contract their teaching force with no commitment, cost, or accountability (Bousquet; Slaughter and Rhoades).

Impact on Teaching Quality and Student Experience

- This labor model treats teaching as expendable gig work rather than a valued profession requiring expertise, development, and support. When instructors are paid by the course with no job security, no expectation of continuity, and no compensation for anything beyond minimal contact hours, teaching becomes transactional—deliver content, grade assignments, submit grades, move on. The time, care, creativity, relationship-building, mentorship, and intellectual engagement required for excellent, transformative teaching are economically irrational for adjuncts to provide when doing so means working for \$5-\$10 per hour and potentially sacrificing income from additional courses elsewhere (Umbach; Childress; Ehrenberg and Zhang).
- Adjuncts are caught in an impossible ethical bind: They care about students and teaching (which is why they're in the profession despite the exploitation), but providing excellent teaching means working far beyond what they're paid for—subsidizing the institution with their unpaid labor and sacrificing their own survival needs. They must choose between serving students well and serving their own basic needs (Childress; Bousquet).
- This employment model systematically undermines teaching quality and mentorship opportunities. Adjuncts cannot invest in thoughtful course development and redesign, stay current with pedagogical research and innovations, learn and implement new teaching technologies effectively, build deep relationships with students over time, provide extensive formative feedback on student work, or offer robust mentorship when they're racing between multiple campuses, juggling 4-6 different course preparations, teaching 6-8 sections to cobble

together near-living wages, and uncertain whether they'll even return next semester (Umbach; Figlio et al.; Ehrenberg and Zhang).

- High course loads and multiple preps make good teaching nearly impossible. An adjunct teaching six classes across three campuses—all with different content, student needs, and institutional requirements—cannot possibly prepare adequately, respond thoughtfully to student work, or maintain the intellectual and emotional energy excellent teaching requires (Umbach; Childress).
- Students lose out on mentorship, office hours, continuity, and relationships when instructors are overworked or can't return. Adjuncts who could be transformative mentors—guiding students through major/career decisions, writing strong recommendation letters, connecting students to opportunities, providing intellectual community and support—simply don't have the time, institutional position, or security to provide it. Students may bond with an adjunct instructor who truly sees them, invests in their growth, and believes in their potential—only to have that instructor disappear next semester because their contract wasn't renewed, they couldn't afford to continue for poverty wages, or they had to take a full-time non-academic job to survive. This disrupts student development and breaks trust, particularly for first-generation students, students of color, and other marginalized students for whom these relationships are crucial (Jaeger and Eagan; Ehrenberg and Zhang; Figlio et al.).
- Adjuncts cannot write strong recommendation letters for graduate school, jobs, or scholarships because they don't have time to get to know students deeply, may not even be employed by the institution when students need letters (years after the course), and lack institutional standing to write credible letters (Childress; Umbach).
- Advising is impossible when adjuncts don't know program requirements, aren't around long enough to build relationships, or aren't compensated for advising time (Jaeger and Eagan).
- High instructor turnover disrupts curriculum coherence, departmental culture, and institutional knowledge. When 50-70% of teaching staff changes each year—contracts not renewed, adjuncts finding other work, adjuncts unable to continue—maintaining curricular sequences (where Course B builds on Course A), shared standards and expectations, consistent pedagogical approaches, and institutional memory about what works becomes impossible. Programs lack coherence; students experience disjointed education with varying expectations and gaps in learning (Jaeger and Eagan; Ehrenberg and Zhang).
- Curriculum innovation requires continuity and collaboration that turnover prevents. Departments cannot implement program-wide changes when most instructors aren't around long-term (Umbach; Schuster and Finkelstein).
- Adjuncts cannot engage in the full scope of academic work essential to vibrant intellectual communities: advising students on major choices, career paths, and graduate school applications; serving on thesis or capstone committees (often they're not allowed to); participating in curriculum development and program assessment (they're excluded);

contributing to institutional service like admissions, retention initiatives, or faculty search committees (they have no standing); conducting research that informs their teaching and models scholarly engagement for students; or participating in professional communities through conferences and publications (they cannot afford time or registration/travel costs). This impoverishes both the adjuncts (whose intellectual and professional development stagnates) and the institution (which loses diverse perspectives and expertise) (Rhoades; Coalition on the Academic Workforce; American Association of University Professors).

- The two-tier system creates profound ethical problems and undermines educational mission. Students paying the same tuition—\$30,000-\$60,000+ per year—may be taught primarily or exclusively by instructors with no job security beyond the current semester, no offices for consultations, no institutional support or resources, no time for mentorship due to overwork, and no commitment from the institution—while a privileged few students (often those in small upper-level seminars, graduate programs, or honors programs) have access to tenured faculty with time, resources, security, and institutional standing. This inequity is rarely disclosed in recruitment materials or explained to students and families making enrollment decisions. Students don't know that the faculty teaching their required courses may be living in cars (Childress; Figlio et al.; Ginsberg).
- The bait-and-switch is fraudulent: Universities market themselves based on prestigious tenure-track faculty, then assign students to courses taught by exploited adjuncts (Ginsberg; Childress).
- Community colleges—serving first-generation students, working-class students, and students of color disproportionately—often have the highest adjunct usage (70-90% of instruction in some cases), meaning the most vulnerable students receive the least stable, most under-resourced instruction (Phillippe; Jaeger and Eagan).
- Adjuncts' stress, burnout, financial desperation, and mental health struggles directly affect classroom environment and student outcomes. Research consistently demonstrates that instructor well-being impacts student engagement, learning outcomes, classroom climate, and students' own mental health ("Their Wellbeing Affects Our Wellbeing"; Tucker et al.). Burnt-out, anxious, financially desperate instructors battling depression and hopelessness cannot create optimal learning environments—warm, intellectually engaging spaces where students feel seen, challenged, and supported—no matter how dedicated they are or how much they care. The system sets up adjuncts to fail students despite their best intentions.
- Students sense instructor stress and precarity, even when not explicitly discussed. The rushed, transactional feel of courses taught by overworked adjuncts—brief office hours (or none), slow email responses, generic feedback, lack of relationship—communicates to students that they don't matter, reinforcing their own precarity and disengagement ("Their Wellbeing Affects Our Wellbeing").

The Knowledge Economy's Dirty Secret

- The adjunct crisis reflects broader issues of labor exploitation in the knowledge economy and the dismantling of middle-class work. Adjunctification is part of larger trends reshaping work across industries: the gig-ification of employment (Uber, DoorDash, TaskRabbit—and now higher education), the dismantling of worker protections and benefits built over a century of labor organizing, the concentration of wealth and security at the very top while labor is devalued and casualized, the treatment of highly skilled workers as interchangeable, expendable commodities rather than professionals worthy of investment and development, and the shifting of risk from institutions/employers onto individual workers who bear all the costs of unemployment, illness, and aging without security or support (Kezar et al.; Slaughter and Rhoades; Bousquet).
- If society accepts adjunctification of teaching—exploitation of highly credentialed knowledge workers—we normalize precarity for all knowledge work: journalism, law, medicine, tech, creative professions. The adjunct is the canary in the coal mine for the professional class (Kezar et al.; Bousquet).
- Higher education—which should model ethical labor practices and value knowledge work—instead leads the race to the bottom, demonstrating that even terminal degrees offer no protection from exploitation. This sends a chilling message across the economy (Giroux; Slaughter and Rhoades).
- Higher education uniquely exploits workers' passion, calling, and commitment. Universities leverage instructors' love of teaching, intellectual commitment to their disciplines, dedication to students, and identification as teachers and scholars to extract labor far beyond what's compensated or sustainable. "Do it for the students," "Do it for the love of learning," "Teaching is a calling, not just a job"—these narratives become justifications for exploitation, suggesting that expecting fair pay and decent conditions means you don't really care or don't belong in academia (Childress; Bousquet; Kezar et al.).
- Passion and calling are weaponized against workers, making them complicit in their own exploitation and feel guilty for expecting basic dignity (Childress; Bousquet).
- The system relies on people's hope, desperation, sunk costs, and identity. Adjuncts continue in exploitative conditions because: they hope for a tenure-track job (the academic lottery ticket—keep buying tickets even though odds are 1 in 100+), they've invested 5-10+ years in education and training (PhD plus often postdocs) and can't psychologically accept that it was for nothing (sunk cost fallacy), they identify deeply as teachers, scholars, historians, philosophers, sociologists—it's not just what they do but who they are, and they have few alternatives with specialized degrees (what does one do with a PhD in medieval literature or continental philosophy besides teach?). The system exploits all of these psychological and structural vulnerabilities (Cassuto; Childress; Bousquet).

- Leaving academia often feels like personal failure and death of identity, even when it's the rational choice for survival. Adjuncts grieve leaving even as the profession destroys them (Cassuto; Childress).
- Academia's prestige masks its exploitative labor practices. From the outside, being a college professor sounds prestigious, intellectual, secure, and middle-class—tenure, summers off, intellectual freedom, respect. The reality of adjuncting—poverty wages, no security, no benefits, no respect, no intellectual life (no time for research or reading), grueling working conditions—shocks people outside academia who assume "professor" means security and status. This gap between cultural perception and lived reality adds to adjuncts' shame and isolation—people don't understand why they're struggling, assume they're exaggerating or bad with money, and offer unhelpful advice ("Just get a real job," "Why did you get a PhD if there are no jobs?") (Childress; Kezar et al.).
- The prestige of the PhD becomes a curse: It represents both immense achievement and devastating failure—the credential that was supposed to ensure middle-class security instead ensures precarity (Cassuto; Childress).
- The system produces brilliant, highly educated people and then treats them as disposable—intellectually and morally bankrupt. PhDs take 5-7+ years to complete (often 8-10 in humanities), requiring extraordinary intellectual capacity, years of rigorous training, comprehensive exams demonstrating mastery of entire fields, original research contributing new knowledge, a 200-400 page dissertation, and often significant financial sacrifice (opportunity cost, debt, poverty-level stipends). Then the system that trained them—that demanded this investment, that certified their expertise—tells them they're not worth a living wage or basic respect, that they're interchangeable and replaceable, that their knowledge and skills have no value. This is not just economic exploitation—it's existential cruelty and intellectual betrayal (Cassuto; Bousquet; Childress).

Intersecting Vulnerabilities and Inequities

- Women, especially mothers, are disproportionately pushed into and trapped in adjunct positions due to structural sexism in academic hiring and retention: lack of paid parental leave (forcing women to drop out of tenure-track pipelines), inflexible tenure clocks that penalize caregiving, gendered expectations around childcare (women academics do 2-3x the caregiving of men), the "two-body problem" (trailing spouses, often women, cannot find tenure-track positions in same locations), and discrimination in hiring (implicit bias, pregnancy discrimination, caregiving seen as lack of commitment). Women adjuncts face both labor precarity and sexism—they're expected to do more emotional and service labor (student support, mentoring, committee work) while being paid less, and they experience sexual harassment without protection or recourse (Misra et al.; Guarino and Borden; Griffin et al.).

- The "mommy penalty" in academia is severe: Women with children are less likely to be hired, promoted, or tenured, and more likely to be relegated to contingent positions (Misra et al.; Guarino and Borden).
- Women adjuncts often cannot afford childcare on poverty wages, forcing impossible choices between work and caregiving, or relying on informal arrangements, family help, or teaching while children are in school (limiting availability) (American Federation of Teachers; Kenner and Bacon).
- Scholars of color are overrepresented among adjuncts and underrepresented in tenured positions, reflecting systemic racism in academic hiring, retention, and promotion pipelines. Black, Latino, and Indigenous PhDs face discrimination in hiring (implicit bias, cultural fit arguments, predominantly white search committees), hostile work environments that push them out of tenure-track positions into contingency, and barriers to tenure (higher standards, less mentorship, racism in evaluation). They face precarity compounded by racism—in addition to all the stressors adjuncts face, they experience tokenization (being one of few or only faculty of color), cultural taxation (asked to do extra diversity work without compensation), microaggressions and overt racism from colleagues and students, and isolation in predominantly white institutions without community or support (Griffin et al.; Flaherty, "The Souls of Black Professors"; Misra et al.).
- Adjuncts of color are less likely to be hired, less likely to be paid fairly, and face racist evaluations from students and administrators that threaten contract renewals (Griffin et al.; Flaherty, "The Souls of Black Professors").
- First-generation academics often lack the social and cultural capital to navigate the opaque, insider pathways to tenure-track positions. Academia rewards those who understand unwritten rules, have mentors and networks, know how to professionalize (publications, conferences, grants), and can afford unpaid or low-paid positions (postdocs, visiting positions) that build CVs. First-gen scholars often lack these advantages, ending up stuck in adjunct roles despite strong qualifications and deep commitment. They may not have family financial support to survive poverty wages or professional networks to learn about hidden opportunities (Childress; Cassuto).
- First-gen scholars experience additional isolation and imposter syndrome, feeling they don't belong in academia and lacking models for navigating it successfully (Childress).
- Adjuncts with disabilities face compounded challenges: no workplace accommodations (can't request them without risking non-renewal), no sick leave (must work through flares or symptom exacerbations or lose income), inability to afford healthcare and medications to manage conditions, inaccessible campuses and facilities (broken elevators, no accessible bathrooms, long walks between buildings when freeway flying), and fear of disclosing disabilities that might lead to non-renewal or stereotypes about capability. The stress of precarity worsens

health conditions; worsening conditions make working harder—a vicious cycle (American Federation of Teachers; Childress).

- Chronic illnesses may develop or worsen under the stress and deprivation of adjunct life—autoimmune conditions, cardiovascular disease, diabetes—without access to care (Kenner and Bacon; Childress).
- International scholars on visas face unique, existential precarity: visa status (F-1, H-1B, J-1) may depend on continuous employment, making the threat of job loss not just financial but existential (deportation, separation from family, loss of ability to work in the U.S.). They cannot access many safety net benefits U.S. citizens can (unemployment, SNAP, Medicaid), face additional employment restrictions, and may be unable to work second jobs to supplement income. The power imbalance is extreme—institutions hold their ability to remain in the country (Kezar et al.; Childress).
- International adjuncts are particularly vulnerable to exploitation, having fewer options and more to lose, creating conditions for abuse (Kezar et al.).
- Graduate students are the ultimate contingent labor: teaching and researching full-time (often 20-40+ hours per week) while classified as students rather than workers, paid poverty-level stipends (\$15,000-\$30,000 annually in most programs, sometimes less, sometimes nothing), receiving minimal or no benefits, facing all the exploitation of adjuncts plus the additional power dynamics of student status (faculty power over grades, degree completion, recommendations, and future careers creates profound vulnerability to exploitation and abuse), and being trained for jobs that don't exist while their labor subsidizes the university ("Under Compulsion"; Evans et al.; Cassuto; Larson et al.). Graduate student exploitation is the foundation on which adjunctification is built.
- Graduate programs gatekeep not just on merit but on financial capacity to survive poverty for 5-10 years, excluding working-class students and students without family support (Cassuto; Childress).

Collective Action and Resistance

- Adjunct unionization is growing as instructors organize for better pay, benefits, job security, and working conditions. Unions like SEIU (Service Employees International Union), AFT (American Federation of Teachers), AAUP (American Association of University Professors), and independent faculty unions have organized adjuncts at hundreds of institutions, winning significant improvements: pay increases (sometimes 30-50%+), access to health insurance, job security provisions (seniority systems, multi-year contracts), grievance procedures, professional development funding, and inclusion in governance. Unionization has measurably improved adjunct working conditions where it exists ("New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid"; Berry; Rhoades; McNaughtan et al.).

- Adjunct organizing faces intense opposition from administrations who threaten, intimidate, surveil, and retaliate against organizers, delay contract negotiations for years, claim poverty while sitting on massive endowments, and manipulate worker classifications to prevent unionization (Berry; Rhoades).
- Landmark campaigns like the "Adjunct Project" collected data crowdsourcing adjunct pay rates, exposing the exploitation and making it visible. #AdjunctCrisis hashtag campaigns raised awareness (New Faculty Majority).
- National Adjunct Walkout Day and organizing efforts have made the exploitation visible, disrupted operations, and forced public conversations. Media coverage of adjunct poverty (articles in The Atlantic, The Chronicle of Higher Education, Inside Higher Ed) has changed public perception (Berry; Childress).
- Student solidarity matters and is growing. When students understand that their instructors are struggling—living in cars, skipping meals, unable to afford healthcare—they can advocate for better institutional practices, recognize that their education quality is tied to instructor working conditions, and join campaigns demanding change. Students have organized rallies, written petitions, testified at board meetings, and refused to cross picket lines in support of adjunct faculty (Berry; McNaughtan et al.).
- Student-adjunct alliances are powerful because students have moral authority and institutions care about their satisfaction (customers) in ways they don't care about adjunct well-being (Berry).
- Some institutions have converted adjunct lines to full-time lecturer positions with better pay (\$40,000-\$60,000+), benefits, multi-year contracts (3-5 years), pathways to continuing/permanent status, and inclusion in governance—proving that change is possible when there's political will. These conversions should be celebrated as victories while recognizing they're insufficient—the goal should be tenure-track or equivalent permanent positions (McNaughtan et al.; Rhoades).
- Resistance comes at great personal risk for adjuncts, who can be easily fired for organizing, speaking publicly, or even just associating with union efforts. Contingent workers have none of the academic freedom protections that tenure provides. Organizers have been blacklisted across institutions, had contracts not renewed in retaliation, faced legal threats, and experienced professional destruction for demanding basic dignity. The courage required to organize under these conditions is immense (Berry; Bousquet).
- Tenure-track faculty solidarity is essential but often lacking. Some tenured faculty organize alongside contingent colleagues, using their privilege and protection to shield vulnerable workers. Others ignore, minimize, or benefit from exploitation, enjoying smaller classes and reduced service because adjuncts absorb the teaching and are excluded from governance. Academic labor solidarity across tiers is necessary for transformative change (Berry; Rhoades; American Association of University Professors).

What Needs to Change: Demands and Vision

Immediate Material Needs:

- Living wages and benefits: Adjuncts should earn salaries proportional to their education, expertise, and workload—minimum \$60,000-\$75,000 for full-time equivalent teaching (4-5 courses per semester) or \$8,000-\$10,000 per course minimum for actual part-time work, with full health insurance, employer retirement contributions, paid sick leave (minimum 10-15 days), parental leave, and professional development funding (American Association of University Professors; "New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid")
- Job security: Multi-year contracts (3-5 years minimum) for all contingent positions, transparent renewal processes with clear criteria and due process, presumption of renewal absent cause, pathways to permanent/continuing status after reasonable time periods (3-5 years), and grievance procedures protecting against arbitrary non-renewal ("Adjuncts Emphasize Need for Contracts"; Kezar et al.; Berry)
- Equitable working conditions: Private office space or dedicated shared offices with privacy for student consultations, institutional email and IT support, library and database access, professional development funding (conference travel, research funds), parking permits and campus access, and inclusion in all department and institutional communications (Coalition on the Academic Workforce; American Federation of Teachers)
- Compensation for all work: Explicit payment for office hours, student advising, email correspondence, professional service, committee work, course development, assessment work, professional meetings, recommendation letters, and all other academic labor—not subsuming these into per-course rates that make actual hourly wages exploitative (Magness; American Federation of Teachers)
- Transparent pay scales and contracts: Publicly available pay rates, clear policies on raises and promotion, written contracts provided well in advance (minimum 6 months before semester), and elimination of contracts issued after semester begins ("Adjuncts Emphasize Need for Contracts"; Government Accountability Office)

Structural Changes:

- Cap on adjunct/contingent usage: No more than 25-30% of instruction should be taught by contingent faculty, requiring institutions to invest in tenure-track or permanent full-time positions, stopping the replacement of tenure-track lines with adjuncts, and converting long-term adjunct positions to tenure-track or permanent lines (Kezar et al.; Schuster and Finkelstein)
- Right of first refusal and seniority systems: Long-term adjuncts get priority for course assignments and consideration for tenure-track openings, recognizing their investment and experience (Berry; Rhoades)

- Inclusion in governance: Full voting rights in curriculum decisions, hiring committees, departmental governance, and faculty senate for all faculty regardless of employment status (Rhoades; American Association of University Professors)
- Transparency and accountability: Institutions should publicly report faculty employment data (percentages of tenure-track, adjunct, and graduate student instruction), adjunct pay scales, benefits access, retention rates, and working conditions as part of accreditation and public accountability (Government Accountability Office; "Annual Report on the Economic Status of the Profession, 2024-25")

Mental Health and Support:

- Employee Assistance Programs (EAPs): Free confidential counseling services for adjuncts equivalent to tenure-track faculty access (Tucker et al.; Evans et al.)
- Mental health leave: Paid mental health days and medical leave provisions (American Federation of Teachers)
- Destigmatization: Institutional cultures that normalize help-seeking and treat mental health as systemic workplace issue, not individual failing (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.)
- Healthcare access: Subsidized or free health insurance for all adjuncts, regardless of hours or contractual status ("An Army of Temps"; "Adjunct Faculty | Current Employees")

Systemic Reform:

- Graduate program reform and accountability: Stop overproducing PhDs for non-existent jobs, provide honest transparent data on job placement outcomes before students enroll, prepare graduate students for diverse career paths beyond tenure-track (alt-ac, administration, industry, K-12, policy), reduce cohort sizes to match realistic job availability, and hold programs accountable for outcomes (Cassuto; Larson et al.; Roy et al.)
- Fund graduate students adequately: Pay living stipends (\$35,000-\$50,000+ depending on COL), provide full benefits, limit teaching hours to protect dissertation progress, and treat graduate students as workers, not just trainees ("Under Compulsion"; Evans et al.)
- Reinvest in public higher education: State and federal funding to lower tuition, expand tenure-track positions, reduce adjunct reliance, and reverse decades of disinvestment (Newfield; "Recent Trends in the Cost of College")
- Cultural change: Value teaching as core academic work, equal to or more important than research; respect and recognize adjunct labor; end the prestige hierarchy that devalues teaching; and challenge the exploitation as morally unconscionable (Childress; Bousquet; Giroux)

Why Society Must Act

- Higher education is a public good, essential to democracy, social mobility, innovation, and informed citizenship, and its quality depends fundamentally on the well-being, stability, and

support of its instructors. Exploiting adjuncts degrades education for everyone—not just adjuncts, but students who deserve excellent teaching and society that depends on educated citizens (Newfield; Readings; Giroux).

- Students deserve better and are being cheated. They (and their families, and taxpayers in public systems) pay tens of thousands of dollars in tuition expecting quality education from supported, secure, fairly compensated educators who can invest fully in their learning—not instructors living in cars and cycling through multiple institutions just to survive. The financial exploitation of adjuncts subsidizes administrative bloat, luxury facilities, and endowment growth while undermining the core mission of teaching and learning ("Recent Trends in the Cost of College"; Ginsberg; Figlio et al.).
 - The social contract is broken—a betrayal and fraud. Society told these individuals to get advanced degrees, that education was the path to stable, meaningful work and middle-class security, that PhD was the highest achievement guaranteeing respect and livelihood. Then it abandoned them to poverty and precarity, blaming them for circumstances structurally created. This betrayal undermines faith in education, meritocracy, and institutions (Cassuto; Childress; Bousquet).
 - This is a moral issue and human rights crisis. Allowing highly educated, skilled people to live in poverty—experiencing food and housing insecurity, unable to access healthcare, suffering mental health crises without support—while administrators earn \$500,000-\$1,000,000+ salaries and universities accumulate billion-dollar endowments is morally unconscionable, a grotesque injustice that violates basic human dignity. We have the resources; we're choosing not to use them to support human beings doing essential work ("How Harvard University's Funding Works"; "Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Kenner and Bacon; Ginsberg).
 - What happens in higher education reflects and shapes broader labor trends. If we accept the adjunctification of teaching—systematic exploitation of highly credentialed knowledge workers—we normalize the gig-ification and precarity of all knowledge work: journalism, law, creative professions, healthcare, technology. The fight for adjunct justice is part of the larger fight for worker dignity, labor rights, and resistance to the corporate dismantling of secure employment everywhere. Higher education should lead in modeling ethical labor practices; instead it's leading the race to the bottom (Kezar et al.; Slaughter and Rhoades; Bousquet; Giroux).
 - Democracy requires educated citizens and critical thinkers developed through quality education. Undermining teaching through exploitation undermines democracy itself (Readings; Giroux; Newfield).
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The Bottom Line

The adjunct crisis is not an accident, a natural market outcome, or a temporary budget problem—it's a deliberate, systematic restructuring of higher education that prioritizes profit maximization over people, educational mission, and human dignity (Bousquet; Slaughter and Rhoades; Kezar et al.), exploits workers' passion, credentials, and desperation (Childress; Cassuto), and treats teaching—the core work of education—as a commodity and expendable gig work rather than a skilled profession worthy of investment, support, and respect (Umbach; Ehrenberg and Zhang). Highly educated, deeply committed, brilliant instructors are living in poverty, experiencing food and housing insecurity (Kenner and Bacon; "Report Shows Alarming Poverty"; Goldrick-Rab et al.), suffering mental health crises without access to care (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.; Tucker et al.), and being denied the basic dignity of stable employment and living wages—all while doing the majority of undergraduate teaching at American colleges and universities (June; Johnson and Fuesting; American Association of University Professors) and being told their exploitation is necessary, inevitable, or somehow their own fault for "choosing" humanities fields or not being "competitive enough" for jobs that don't exist (Cassuto; Larson et al.; Roy et al.). This system harms adjuncts catastrophically, degrades educational quality measurably (Umbach; Figlio et al.; Jaeger and Eagan), betrays students who deserve better ("Their Wellbeing Affects Our Wellbeing"; Ehrenberg and Zhang), and corrupts the mission and integrity of higher education as an institution dedicated to knowledge, truth, and human flourishing (Readings; Ginsberg; Giroux). Adjuncts are not "temporary," "supplemental," or "part-time"—they are the teaching workforce (Johnson and Fuesting; Government Accountability Office), and they deserve living wages that allow them to afford housing and healthcare, job security that allows them to plan beyond the current semester, full benefits including health insurance and retirement, respect as the credentialed professionals and experts they are, offices and resources to do their work effectively, and the institutional support necessary to teach well and live with dignity (American Association of University Professors; "New AFT Report: Adjunct Faculty Remain Underpaid"; Berry). Until higher education reckons honestly with this exploitation, names it as such, and commits to transformative structural change—not cosmetic improvements or small pay bumps, but fundamental reinvestment in teaching as valued work deserving of tenure-track or equivalent permanent, secure, fairly compensated positions (Kezar et al.; Schuster and Finkelstein; Newfield)—the crisis will deepen, more brilliant people will be destroyed by a system that trained them and then discarded them (Cassuto; Childress; Evans et al.), and everyone invested in education, knowledge, justice, and human dignity should be outraged, organizing, and demanding better (Berry; Rhoades; Bousquet). The current system is morally bankrupt, intellectually indefensible, and unsustainable. We can do better. We must do better. Adjuncts, students, and the future of education depend on it.

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1. What is the social issue?

The social issue is the **systematic exploitation of adjunct and contingent faculty in American higher education and its devastating consequences for workers' mental health, economic security, and dignity—and for educational quality**. Over 70% of all college instructors in the United States are now contingent faculty—adjuncts, lecturers, graduate student instructors—who teach the majority of undergraduate courses for poverty wages (\$2,000-\$5,000 per course, often yielding annual incomes of \$12,000-\$30,000), receive no health insurance, retirement benefits, or paid leave, have no job security beyond a single semester, and are systematically excluded from governance, institutional support, and professional community (American Association of University Professors; Government Accountability Office; Kezar et al.). This workforce—holding master's degrees and PhDs, doing the core work of education—experiences depression, anxiety, food and housing insecurity, and burnout at alarming rates, yet has virtually no access to mental health resources or workplace accommodations (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.). This exploitation is not an accidental byproduct of budget constraints but a deliberate structural transformation of higher education into a two-tiered labor caste system that prioritizes administrative growth, facilities spending, and endowment accumulation over teaching, learning, and human dignity (Ginsberg; Bousquet; Childress).

2. Why does this issue interest you?

This issue is deeply compelling because it exposes a fundamental hypocrisy at the heart of American higher education: institutions that claim to advance knowledge, develop human potential, promote social mobility, and model ethical engagement with the world are simultaneously running one of the most exploitative labor systems in the American economy. Universities teach students about labor rights, economic justice, and human dignity in courses taught by instructors who have none of these things—creating a moral contradiction that undermines the entire intellectual project. The crisis is also revealing because it demonstrates how passion and calling can be weaponized against workers: adjuncts continue under exploitative conditions not because they're irrational but because their identities, training, intellectual commitments, and years of investment bind them to work they love in a system designed to extract maximum value from that love while returning minimum compensation. The adjunct crisis is the knowledge economy's canary in the coal mine—if society accepts the impoverishment of PhD-holding professionals doing essential work, it normalizes precarity for all skilled labor. And the mental health consequences—depression, anxiety, suicidal ideation, shame, isolation—are not personal failures but predictable, systemic outcomes of poverty wages, chronic insecurity, and institutional abandonment that demand structural, not individual, solutions.

3. Who is most affected by this issue?

The most affected groups include:

- **Adjunct and contingent faculty** broadly—over 70% of all college instructors, approximately 1.5 million people—who earn poverty wages, lack benefits and security, and experience high rates of mental health distress, food insecurity, and housing instability
 - **Women in academia**, particularly mothers, who are disproportionately pushed into contingent positions due to structural sexism in hiring and tenure processes, the "mommy penalty," inflexible tenure clocks that penalize caregiving, and gendered expectations around service and emotional labor (Misra et al.; Guarino and Borden)
 - **Scholars of color**, particularly Black, Latino/a, and Indigenous academics, who are overrepresented among adjuncts and underrepresented in tenured positions, face racism in hiring and evaluation, bear disproportionate "cultural taxation" (diversity work, mentoring students of color), and experience precarity compounded by racial discrimination (Griffin et al.; Flaherty, "The Souls of Black Professors")
 - **First-generation academics** who lack the social and cultural capital, family financial support, and professional networks to navigate opaque pathways to stable academic employment—and who experience acute imposter syndrome compounded by economic precarity
 - **Graduate students** who are the foundational contingent labor force—teaching and researching full-time for poverty stipends while classified as "students" rather than workers, trained for tenure-track jobs that overwhelmingly do not exist (Evans et al.; Cassuto; Larson et al.)
 - **International scholars on visas** whose immigration status depends on employment, creating existential vulnerability to exploitation with virtually no recourse
 - **Adjuncts with disabilities and chronic illnesses** who cannot access workplace accommodations, cannot afford healthcare to manage conditions, and experience worsening health under the stress of precarity
 - **Students**—particularly first-generation, low-income, and students of color at community colleges and public institutions with the highest adjunct usage—who receive instruction from overworked, under-resourced, and institutionally unsupported faculty, undermining the quality of education they're paying for (Ehrenberg and Zhang; Umbach; Jaeger and Eagan)
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4. Is this issue mostly about individual choices, social structures, or both?

This issue is overwhelmingly about **social structures**, though it is persistently mischaracterized as a matter of individual career choices, personal resilience, or market outcomes. Structurally, adjunct exploitation is produced and maintained by:

- **The deliberate restructuring of academic labor:** Beginning in the 1980s-1990s, universities systematically replaced retiring tenure-track faculty with low-cost adjuncts—not as temporary budget response but as permanent labor strategy designed to maximize institutional flexibility and minimize labor costs (Bousquet; Schuster and Finkelstein; Kezar et al.)

- **State disinvestment in public higher education:** Decades of funding cuts shifted costs onto students (through tuition) and workers (through wage suppression), while administrative spending grew dramatically (Newfield; Ginsberg)
- **Administrative bloat:** The number of administrators and their salaries have grown vastly faster than faculty, consuming resources that could fund tenure-track positions (Ginsberg)
- **Academic capitalism:** The transformation of universities into market-driven enterprises prioritizing revenue generation, brand management, endowment growth, and competitive positioning over educational mission and labor equity (Slaughter and Rhoades)
- **PhD overproduction:** Graduate programs continue admitting large cohorts for non-existent tenure-track jobs, creating a surplus labor pool that depresses wages and keeps adjuncts desperate and compliant—the same universities that overproduce PhDs then hire them as cheap labor (Cassuto; Larson et al.)
- **The erosion of collective bargaining:** Anti-union legislation and institutional resistance to adjunct unionization prevent workers from collectively demanding better conditions (Berry; Rhoades)
- **Regulatory failure:** No federal or state regulations mandate minimum pay, benefits, or job security for adjunct faculty—leaving working conditions entirely at institutional discretion
- **Cultural narratives that weaponize passion:** The framing of teaching as a "calling" rather than labor, the expectation of self-sacrifice for students, and the stigmatization of demanding fair compensation as evidence of insufficient commitment all serve institutional interests by making workers complicit in their own exploitation (Childress; Kezar et al.)

Individual adjuncts did not choose this system, cannot individually change it, and are trapped within structures designed to keep them powerless. The "choice" narrative—"you chose this career," "you knew the market"—is victim-blaming that obscures institutional responsibility for creating and maintaining exploitative conditions.

5. Which library resource seems most useful for this topic?

Academic databases such as **ERIC (Education Resources Information Center)**, **JSTOR**, and **Sociological Abstracts** would be the most useful library resources for this topic. ERIC contains extensive research on higher education labor, faculty working conditions, contingent faculty outcomes, and the relationship between instructor employment status and student achievement. JSTOR provides access to key journals like *Review of Higher Education*, *Journal of Human Resources*, *Educational Policy*, and *Academe* where foundational research on adjunctification, academic labor markets, and faculty governance has been published. Sociological Abstracts indexes research on labor stratification, occupational mental health, precarious work, the gig economy, and institutional analysis—the broader

sociological frameworks needed to understand adjunct exploitation as part of larger patterns of labor restructuring, inequality, and the commodification of knowledge work.

6. What kind of information might sociologists study about this issue?

Sociologists might study:

- **Labor and work sociology:** How adjunctification fits within broader patterns of labor casualization, gig-ification, and the erosion of standard employment relationships across the economy—examining parallels between adjuncts and other precarious workers (gig workers, temps, contractors) and whether adjuncts represent the vanguard of professional-class proletarianization
- **Organizational sociology and institutional analysis:** How universities make decisions about faculty employment—examining the role of administrative growth, board composition, corporate governance models, accreditation pressures, enrollment management, and institutional competition in driving adjunctification (Ginsberg; Slaughter and Rhoades)
- **Stratification and class reproduction:** How the two-tiered faculty system maps onto and reproduces class, race, and gender inequality—examining who becomes adjuncts, who gets tenure-track jobs, and how these outcomes reflect structural advantages (wealth, networks, prestige, demographics) rather than merit alone
- **Occupational mental health:** Prevalence and determinants of depression, anxiety, burnout, suicidal ideation, and other mental health outcomes among contingent faculty—examining how financial precarity, job insecurity, lack of institutional belonging, and chronic stress produce psychological distress as systemic outcome rather than individual vulnerability (Evans et al.; Levecque et al.; Mullainathan and Shafir)
- **Gender and academic labor:** How the feminization of contingent positions, gendered service expectations, the "mommy penalty," and sexual harassment vulnerability intersect with precarity to produce compounded disadvantage for women in academia (Misra et al.; Guarino and Borden)
- **Race and academic labor:** How scholars of color are channeled into contingent positions through discrimination in hiring and tenure processes, how "cultural taxation" adds uncompensated labor burden, and how racial isolation compounds the psychological toll of precarity (Griffin et al.; Flaherty, "The Souls of Black Professors")
- **The political economy of higher education:** How neoliberal restructuring, state disinvestment, financialization, and the commodification of education have transformed universities from public institutions serving democratic purposes into market-driven enterprises extracting value from workers and students (Slaughter and Rhoades; Newfield; Brown)

- **Social movements and collective action:** How adjuncts organize despite structural barriers to unionization—examining successful and failed campaigns, the role of solidarity across employment tiers, student-faculty alliances, and the conditions enabling collective action among precarious workers (Berry; Rhoades; McNaughtan et al.)
 - **Stigma, identity, and shame:** How adjuncts manage the contradiction between high educational credentials and low economic status—examining identity work, impression management, concealment of poverty, and the psychological toll of status inconsistency
 - **The hidden curriculum of academic labor:** What the exploitation of adjuncts teaches students about the value of knowledge work, intellectual labor, and education itself—and how the visible precarity of their instructors shapes students' own career aspirations and faith in education
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7. What is one question you would like to ask about this issue?

To what extent does the deliberate overproduction of PhDs by graduate programs that financially benefit from graduate student labor—while knowing that tenure-track positions are vanishing—constitute a form of institutional fraud, and how does the resulting surplus labor pool function structurally to suppress adjunct wages, prevent collective bargaining, and maintain the exploitative two-tiered academic labor system that universities have deliberately constructed?